“I can't be loved or happy without my spouse.”

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Where it often comes from

A close marriage can become central to your sense of belonging. Fear of abandonment, bereavement, separation, betrayal, or past rejection may make life without your spouse seem unbearable. Isolation and giving up friendships or interests can make one relationship feel like your only possible source of love.

What Scripture teaches

The Bible honors the deep bond of marriage and also shows that a meaningful life is possible outside it. In Pearls, 1 Corinthians 7:8–9 recognizes unmarried life, and 1 Corinthians 7:39 acknowledges life and choices after a spouse’s death. God draws near to the brokenhearted. Losing a relationship can bring profound grief, but it does not erase your worth or your capacity to receive love, companionship, and moments of joy. Healing takes time, and you do not have to force yourself to feel happy.

> *“The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit”* (Psalm 34:18).

Also see

> “Now to the unmarried and widows I say this: It is good for them to remain unmarried, as I am. But if they cannot control themselves, let them marry. For it is better to marry than to burn with passion” (1 Corinthians 7:8–9).

> “A wife is bound to her husband as long as he lives. But if her husband dies, she is free to marry anyone she wishes, as long as he belongs to the Lord” (1 Corinthians 7:39).

> “Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: ‘Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.’” (Hebrews 13:5).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

Common self-statements

- Without my spouse, nobody could love me.
- If I am alone, my life has no meaning.
- I could never enjoy anything again.
- I must accept anything to keep this relationship.
- Needing support means I cannot cope.
- Being separated or widowed makes me incomplete as a person.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Turning feared loss into certainty that life can contain nothing good.
- Exclusive-source thinking: Treating one person as the only possible source of love.
- Emotional reasoning: Taking today’s grief or fear as a prediction of every future day.
- Conditional worth: Making your value depend on keeping a particular relationship.

Challenging questions

- Does missing my spouse mean I am incapable of receiving love from anyone else?
- Who has cared for me at other times in my life?
- Can deep grief and a brief moment of comfort exist on the same day?
- What would I say to a friend who had lost a spouse?
- Which relationships or activities could I gently reconnect with?
- Am I accepting harmful treatment because I believe I have no other future?

Truth summary

> My spouse is deeply important, but my worth and capacity to be loved do not depend on one person. I may grieve intensely and still receive care from God and other people. With time and support, meaning and moments of joy can grow again. I do not need to accept harm to remain worthy of love.

Selected Scripture references draw on Pearls, "Marriage" (pp. 240–241) and "Marriage Guidance" (pp. 242–244), with other passages selected for this belief. Quotations use the BSB.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Marriage
- Marriage Guidance
- Loneliness
- Grief
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin
God's fatherly love is deeper than human approval or achievement.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't be loved or happy without my spouse"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't be loved or happy without my spouse." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who else has shown me care?
- ☐ Does grief prove I can never feel joy?
- ☐ Can grief and comfort exist together?
- ☐ What would I say to a grieving friend?
- ☐ What support could I accept today?
- ☐ Am I accepting harm because I fear being alone?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Grief does not mean my future is empty.
- ☐ My worth continues when a relationship changes.
- ☐ I can receive care from more than one person.
- ☐ A small moment of comfort does not betray my love.
- ☐ I can ask for support and take one manageable step.
- ☐ I do not have to earn love by accepting harm.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ 1 Corinthians 7:8–9
  "Now to the unmarried and widows I say this: It is good for them to remain unmarried, as I am. But if they cannot control themselves, let them marry. For it is better to marry than to burn with passion."
- ☐ 1 Corinthians 7:39
  "A wife is bound to her husband as long as he lives. But if her husband dies, she is free to marry anyone she wishes, as long as he belongs to the Lord."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Connection-and-comfort record: Record one person, place, activity, or prayer that offered even slight comfort. Note grief honestly rather than trying to erase it.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  A personal reminder based on James 1:19: "Sarah can practice being quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger."
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Marriage Guidance" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose exercises you can do safely. If there is coercion, violence, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying joint exercises.

- [ ] Contact one safe, supportive person. Ask for a short call, visit, or walk. Predict how alone you will feel afterward, then record the actual result.
- [ ] Try one manageable activity. Choose ten minutes of something meaningful. Rate distress and any comfort before and after; improvement is welcome but not required.
- [ ] Build a small support map. List people and services you could turn to for practical help, companionship, spiritual support, or counseling.
- [ ] Make room for grief and connection. Write one thing you miss and one caring action you can receive today. Consider a grief or separation support group when appropriate.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't be loved or happy without my spouse": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One connection or moment of comfort
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't be loved or happy without my spouse.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Loving Father, stay near in my fear and grief. Help me receive support and remember that my worth has not disappeared. Give me strength for today and openness to the love and meaning that may grow in time. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.